



FIRST-TIME BUYER GUIDE

The First-Time Buyer's Conveyancing Checklist



Your step-by-step path from offer to keys

Buying your first home is exciting — and the legal side can feel like a black box. This checklist walks you through every stage of conveyancing in plain English, so you know what happens next, what to have ready, and how to keep your purchase moving.

Welcome — you've got this

Conveyancing is the legal process of transferring a property into your name. It runs alongside your mortgage and your move, and for most first-time buyers it takes ten to fourteen weeks from an accepted offer to completion.

This guide breaks the whole journey into five clear stages. At each one you'll see what happens, who is responsible, and a checklist of what you can do to keep things on track. Tick the boxes as you go — being a prepared, responsive buyer is the single biggest thing in your control.

Jargon, decoded

Conveyancer = the solicitor or licensed conveyancer who does your legal work.

Disbursements = third-party costs they pay on your behalf (searches, Land Registry).

Exchange = the point your purchase becomes legally binding. Completion = the day you get the keys.

£ Stage 1 — Before you offer

The work you do before you even make an offer decides how smoothly everything else runs. Sort your money and your paperwork first.

Your checklist

- ☐ Get a mortgage Agreement in Principle (AIP) from a lender or broker
- ☐ Confirm exactly how much deposit you have, and where it is held
- ☐ If any of your deposit is gifted, ask the giver for a signed gift letter now
- ☐ Budget for the full cost of moving — not just the price (see Stage 5)
- ☐ Work out your Stamp Duty using an online calculator before you offer
- ☐ Gather photo ID and proof of address ready for identity checks

First-time buyer Stamp Duty relief

As a first-time buyer you pay no Stamp Duty on the first £300,000, and 5% on any portion between £300,000 and £500,000. If the price is above £500,000 the relief does not apply and standard rates are used instead. Always check your exact figure before you offer.

Stage 2 — Offer to exchange

Once your offer is accepted, you instruct a conveyancer and the legal work begins. This is the longest stage, because it includes searches and enquiries that depend on third parties.

1

Instruct your conveyancer

WEEK 1

Choose a conveyancer and formally instruct them. They send a client care letter, run ID checks, take money on account and order searches. Nothing starts until this is done — so do it the day your offer is accepted.

2

Searches & enquiries

WEEKS 2–6

Local authority, water & drainage and environmental searches are ordered, and your conveyancer raises enquiries on the seller's pack. Turnaround varies by council.

3

Mortgage valuation & survey

WEEKS 3–6

Your lender values the property; you arrange your own survey to check its condition. Book the survey early so any problems surface in time.

4

Mortgage offer & report on title

WEEKS 6–8

Your lender issues the formal mortgage offer. Your conveyancer reports to you in plain English on exactly what you are buying.

Your checklist

- ☐ Instruct your conveyancer the same day your offer is accepted
- ☐ Return your ID, signed forms and money on account immediately
- ☐ Book your survey (RICS Level 2 for most homes, Level 3 for older ones)
- ☐ Reply to every question from your conveyancer within 24–48 hours
- ☐ Keep your mortgage broker updated so your formal offer isn't delayed

Watch out for

Until you exchange, either side can still walk away — this is when gazumping can happen. Moving quickly and staying responsive is your best protection against losing the property to another buyer.

Stage 3 — Exchange to completion

Exchange of contracts is the moment your purchase becomes legally binding. You pay your deposit (usually around 10%), a completion date is fixed, and neither side can pull out without serious financial penalty.

Your checklist

- ☐ Have your deposit funds ready to transfer in good time
- ☐ Read and sign your contract and mortgage deed promptly when asked
- ☐ Arrange buildings insurance to start from the date of exchange
- ☐ Do not book removals or hand in rental notice until you have exchanged
- ☐ Confirm your completion date works for your move and your chain

Why exchange matters

Before exchange, nothing is guaranteed. After exchange, the deal is locked in. That's why your conveyancer won't let you commit to removals or notice until contracts are exchanged — it protects you from being left out of pocket if the sale collapses.

Stage 4 — Completion day

Completion is the day the money moves and the property becomes yours. Your conveyancer sends the balance of funds to the seller's conveyancer, and once it arrives the keys are released — usually through the estate agent.

Your checklist

- ☐ Confirm your removals company and timings the day before
- ☐ Be reachable by phone — completion can happen earlier than expected
- ☐ Collect keys from the estate agent once your conveyancer confirms completion
- ☐ Take meter readings as soon as you're in
- ☐ Keep your completion statement safe for the future

A note on timing

Funds move by bank transfer, which has daily cut-off times. Completing late in the day can push your actual move into the afternoon, so plan your removals with some flexibility.

Stage 5 — What it all costs

Beyond the price of the property, here is what to budget for. Your conveyancing quote should itemise every line so there are no surprises.

Cost	Typical amount	What it's for
Legal fee	£900–£1,500 +VAT	Your conveyancer's work on the purchase
Searches	£200–£400	Local authority, water & drainage, environmental
Land Registry fee	£20–£910	Registering you as the new owner (scales with price)
Bank transfer fee	£20–£45	Sending completion funds securely
ID / AML checks	£10–£20 each	Identity and anti-money-laundering verification
Survey	£400–£1,500	Optional but advised — checks the property's condition
Stamp Duty (SDLT)	£0+	A tax, not a fee — first-time buyer relief may apply

Ways to keep costs down

Choose a fixed-fee, itemised quote rather than a low headline figure that grows later. Check whether supplements (leasehold, new build, gifted deposit) are already included. And remember the cheapest quote isn't always the cheapest final bill.

Documents to have ready

Your conveyancer is legally required to verify who you are and where your money comes from. Having these ready up front avoids the single most common delay at the start of a purchase — slow identity and source-of-funds checks.

Your checklist

- ☐ Photo ID — passport or driving licence — for every buyer
- ☐ Proof of address dated within the last three months
- ☐ Proof of deposit: bank statements showing the funds building up
- ☐ If any deposit is gifted: a signed gift letter and the giver's ID
- ☐ Your mortgage Agreement in Principle
- ☐ Details of any scheme you're using (Lifetime ISA, shared ownership, Help to Buy)

Source of funds

Anti-money-laundering rules mean your conveyancer must understand where your deposit came from — savings, a gift, the sale of another property, or an inheritance. A clear paper trail prepared early prevents awkward questions and delays just before exchange.



Common questions

How long does it take to buy a house?

Most purchases complete within ten to fourteen weeks of an accepted offer, with around twelve weeks a realistic average. Chains, leasehold properties and mortgage delays can extend this.

What is the difference between exchange and completion?

Exchange is when the purchase becomes legally binding and you pay your deposit. Completion is when the remaining money is transferred and you get the keys — usually one to two weeks later, sometimes the same day.

Do I really need a survey?

It isn't legally required, but it's strongly advised. The lender's valuation is for their benefit, not yours, and won't tell you about the condition of the property. A survey can save you thousands or give you room to renegotiate.

When do I pay Stamp Duty?

Your conveyancer pays it to HMRC within 14 days of completion, usually from funds you provide on the day. Budget for it from the start — as a first-time buyer you may pay little or none, but check your figure early.

Plain-English glossary

The conveyancing world is full of jargon. Here are the terms you're most likely to meet, decoded.

Term	What it means
Conveyancer	The solicitor or licensed conveyancer who handles your legal work.
Disbursements	Third-party costs your conveyancer pays on your behalf, such as searches and Land Registry fees.
Searches	Checks with the council, water company and others that reveal issues affecting the property.
Title	The legal record of who owns the property and any rights or restrictions over it.
Exchange	The point contracts are swapped and the purchase becomes legally binding.
Completion	The day the money is paid, the keys are released and the home becomes yours.
Freehold	You own the property and the land it stands on outright, with no time limit.
Leasehold	You own the property for the length of a lease, usually paying ground rent or service charges.
Chain	The line of linked buyers and sellers whose transactions all depend on each other.
Gazumping	When a seller accepts a higher offer from someone else before exchange.
SDLT	Stamp Duty Land Tax — a government tax on most property purchases above a threshold.
AIP	Agreement in Principle — a lender's early indication of how much it may lend you.

Ready for your first quote?

Get a fixed, itemised conveyancing quote — reviewed by a real person before it reaches you, with no hidden extras. It takes about two minutes and there's no obligation.

conveyquote.uk